LONER - CORE RULES 1ST EDITION (LEGACY)

Version: 3

Table of contents

Loner (1st Edition) 1
Minimum Requirements 1
Make a Character 2
Start your game 3
Keep the action in motion 4
Advantage and Disadvantage 5
Harm & Luck 5
Doubles and the Twist Counter 7
Determine the Twist 7
Determine the mood of the next scene 8
Sibylline Responses 8
Open-Ended Question or Get Inspired 9
When the story ends 11
Credits 11

Loner (1st Edition)

Another Solo RPG Game

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Loner is a bare-bone freeform solo RPG designed to play with a solo character in “narrative” mode. You’ll guide your character through the story that will unravel during the game, asking closed questions to an oracle who will assume the role of Game Master. Every now and then the game will surprise you when an unexpected plot twist happens!

To play it, it is assumed that you are already familiar with the world of role-playing and solo games. Good places to get an idea are the RPG page on Wikipedia and the Lone Wolf Roleplaying subreddit.

Minimum Requirements

You will need: - **4 six sided dice** (also known as d6s): two pairs of different colors - **paper and writing tools**: at least a sheet of scrap paper and and pencil, but index cards or sticky notes are a fine addition - **character sheet**: you may use the provided sheet at the back or a simple index card. - **notebook**: Loner is not a solo journaling game, you can easily play it in the “theater of mind”. But you can keep track of you game if you feel the need!

Make a Character

Your protagonist (or hero if you wish) is described by some fixed traits:

- **Name**: the name should be iconic and consistent with the tone and setting of the story
- **Concept**: A concise description of the character's profession, background, and abilities. The best are adjective-name pairings, like *"Venturous Smuggler"* or *"Child Prodigy"*.
- **Skills** (x2): abilities not necessarily character-specific but not characteristics common to all. *"Smart"* is not a skill, *"Engine Whisperer"* is.
- **Frailty**: something that could potentially get in the way of the character, either physically, mentally, or socially.
- **Gear** (x2): particular equipment supplied to the character in coherence with the setting. Everyday items are taken for granted and do not fall under this trait.
- **Goal**: the long-term objective.
- **Motive**: what drives the pursuit of the goal.
- **Nemesis**: a person or organization that hinders the protagonist. It can emerge during the first game sessions, it may or may or not be the direct antagonist of the story, ready to appear to make life even more difficult
- **Luck**: 6

Example > **Zahra Nakajima** Witty Street Cat. Streetwise, Nimble, Merciful.
> Knife, Low O2 Supplement.
> She wants to obtain unknown technology to save her planet from atmosphere collapse.
> **Nemesis**: The Naturalist Order
> **Luck**: 6

Everything else in the game is a “character”. The are the living (the Non-Playing Characters), and inanimate characters (such as vehicles and crafts). Inanimate characters do not have goal, motive or a nemesis.

Example > **The Century Skylark** Spacecraft in bad shape. Hyperjump Drive, Camouflage Circuits, Midlife Courier.
> Shields, Turrets.
> **Luck**: 6.

Start your game

Decide on an initial scene for your adventure. Starting the game in the middle of an action scene is a good way to set events in motion. If nothing comes to mind, roll on each of the following questions to generate a random adventure seed.

D6	Who? The proposer	What? The mission	Why? The incentive	Where? The target	How?The seed	Obstacle?The complication
1	Authority	Rescue	Help	Person	Casual encounter	Opposition
2	Organization	Protection	Fortune	Group	Old acquaintance	Deception
3	Ally (friend, relative)	Exploit	Coercion	Treasure	Rumors	Environment
4	Mentor	Explore	Impulse	Location	Capture	Disguise

D6	Who? The proposer	What? The mission	Why? The incentive	Where? The target	How?The seed	Obstacle?The complication
5	Help-seeker	Escape	Ambition	McGuffin	Mishap	Time
6	Blackmailer	Pursuit	Revenge	Confession	Object (map, journal, letter)	Space

Example > **Who?** Mentor
> **What?** Exploit
> **Why?** Help
> **Where?** McGuffin
> **How?** Rumors
> **Obstacle?** Time
> Tobias Wethern took Zahra under his wing when her parents died. That's why she can't say no to him now. Tobias wants Zahra to steal a datapad from the Leton Corporation's subsidiary. He doesn't know precisely where it is stored, but that in 24 hours it will be taken from the company's security corps to be transferred to another location.

Keep the action in motion

A game in Loner is a succession of scenes. A scene is a unit of time in which a certain action takes place in pursuit of a certain short-term goal. In a traditional role-playing game, it is the Game Master who proposes the scene and moves the world and NPCs. In a solo role-playing game, on the other hand, the player asks questions to an Oracle (as he would to a GM) who will provide a closed answer. It is therefore necessary to formulate questions whose answer is binary (Yes, No).

You'll need 2d6 in one color (**Chance Dice**), and 2d6 in another (**Risk Dice**).

To resolve a closed question, roll one **Chance Die** and one **Risk Die**. If the Chance Die is highest, the answer is **Yes**. If the Risk Die is highest, the answer is **No**.

Also look at the value on each die. If both are low (3 or less), add **But**. If both are high (4 or more), add **And**.

Example > You ask, "Does Zahra manage to force the hatch?" You roll one Chance Die and one Risk Die and get (5) [4]). The answer is **Yes**, because the Chance Die is higher. You also add **And**, because both rolls are 4 or higher. If the Risk Die had come up as [3], it would have been a plain **Yes** instead.

Advantage and Disadvantage

If circumstances or positive traits grant an advantage, add a **Chance Die** to the roll. Otherwise, when hindrances or negative traits cause a disadvantage, add a **Risk Die**. In both cases keep only the higher die of the added type when you check the roll.

Example > You ask, "Does Zahra hack the datapad?" You roll one Chance Die and two Risk Die, as Zahra does not have any advantage in hacking and the datapad is the mission goal, compromising it would cause the mission to fail. You get (4) [4] [5]. You discard the lower Risk Die [4] and keep (4) and [5]. You obtain a **No** and add a **And** since they are both 4 or higher. This hacking has gone really bad...

Harm & Luck

When you are in conflict the game is played in turns alternating between the player and NPCs. When you fail your defense, reduce your current Luck according to the table below. NPCs also have a Luck trait. If you attack in any form,

reduce the targets Luck according to the table below. When your Luck runs out you face mortal danger and the next attack will take you out of the conflict.

The final outcome depends on the context. Do you get caught? Are you seriously injured? You may even die if that fits the narrative.

Answer	Do you get what you want?	Harm
Yes, and...	You get what you want, and something else.	Cause 3
Yes...	You get what you want.	Cause 2
Yes, but...	You get what you want, but at a cost.	Cause 1
No, but...	You don't get what you want, but it's not a total loss.	Take 1
No...	You don't get what you were after.	Take 2
No, and...	You don't get what you want, and things get worse.	Take 3

Example > Zahra confronts a thug in an alley. He is "Martial Artist", "Hand-to-Hand Combat", "Feline" and "Short". Zahra tries to hit him with the knife, you throw (5) (6) [4] ("**Yes,**

And...", causing a Luck loss of 3 to the thug). The thug throws a roundhouse kick at Zahra (roll (3) (2) [2], "**Yes, but...**", causing a Luck loss of 1 to Zahra). Who will win?

Doubles and the Twist Counter

The Twist Counter is a measure of the rising tension in the narrative. At the beginning is set to 0. Every time a double throw (dice are equal) happens, add 1 to the Counter. If the Counter is below three, consider the answer as "**Yes, but...**". Otherwise a **Twist** happens and resets the Counter.

Example > You ask if the datapad contains sensitive data about Wethern's illicit activities. You roll (4) [4]. The answers is "Yes, but...". You add 1 to the Twist Counter. But you were already at 2 on the counter, so a twist happens! The counter resets to 0.

Determine the Twist

Roll 2d6 and consult the following Twist Table to determine what kind of twist happens.

D6	Subject	Action
1	A third party	Appears
2	The hero	Alters the location
3	An encounter	Helps the hero
4	A physical event	Hinders the hero
5	An emotional event	Changes the goal
6	An object	Ends the scene

Interpret the two-word sentence in the context of the current scene. Twists will keep the plot and events going in unexpected ways.

Now Zahra knows the content of the datapad, but you roll 1 and 5 on the Twist Table "*A third party*", "*Changes the goal*". An agent of the Leton Corporation appears before Zahra with a proposal....

Determine the mood of the next scene

At the end of the current scene, you may need to determine the general mood of the next one. In this case roll 1d6 and consult the following table:

D6	Next Scene
1-3	Dramatic scene
4-5	Quiet Scene
6	Meanwhile...

- A **dramatic scene** does not break the tension of the previous scene but carries it further forward, introducing further obstacles or difficulties.
- During a **quiet scene** there is time to take a breath, to heal, to make plans for the next steps and to deepen relationships.
- A **meanwhile scene** takes place somewhere else, other than where the hero is. It cuts to villains or other plot-important characters.

Example > Zahra accepts the proposal, you now roll for the next scene: 6, *Meanwhile scene*. In the following scene, Tobias Wethern hires a hit man to kill Zahra...

Sibylline Responses

The Oracle might sometimes give answers that don't make sense in the context of the scene. Don't be tempted to detail the answer with too many questions in sequence. Three questions should be sufficient. If you're still stuck, try using

an open-ended question to unlock yourself or interpret the answer as “Yes, But...” and move the story forward.

Open-Ended Question or Get Inspired

To answer an Open-Ended question, roll 1d6 once on each of the following tables (roll at least a verb and a noun, adjectives are optional).

Verbs	1	2	3	4	5	6
1	inject	pass	own	divide	bury	borrow
2	continue	learn	ask	multiply	receive	imagine
3	develop	behave	replace	damage	collect	turn
4	share	hand	play	explain	improve	cough
5	face	expand	found	gather	prefer	belong
6	trip	want	miss	dry	employ	destroy

Nouns	1	2	3	4	5	6
1	cause	stage	change	verse	thrill	spot
2	front	event	home	bag	measure	birth
3	prose	motion	trade	memory	chance	drop
4	instrument	friend	talk	liquid	fact	price

Nouns	1	2	3	4	5	6
5	word	morn-ing	edge	room	system	camp
6	key	in-come	use	hu-mor	state-ment	argu-ment

Ad-jec-tives	1	2	3	4	5	6
1	fre-quent	faulty	obscene	scarce	rigid	long-term
2	ethe-real	sophis-ticated	right-ful	knowl-edge-able	aston-ishing	ordi-nary
3	de-scrip-tive	insidi-ous	poor	proud	reflec-tive	amus-ing
4	silky	worth-less	fixed	loose	willing	cold
5	quiet	stormy	spooky	delirи-ous	innate	late
6	mag-nifi-cent	arro-gant	unhealthy	enor-mous	trucu-lent	charm-ing

Example > You ask: “Does Zahra have friends to ask for help against the hit man?”. You roll 24 and 32: *multiply motion*. Zahra needs to move quickly to reach Melina Reade, a hacker with contacts in the underworld who might be able to help her!

When the story ends

At the end of the adventure you may add another trait to the character. It is better that this is related to how the story just ended and can be either a Skill, Gear, a new Frailty, or even a new Nemesis! You can also modify an existing trait to better represent an enhanced expertise.

Also note the list of contacts, enemies and any events, people or objects that may show up again in future adventures.

Example > Zahra secures the datapad in the hands of the authorities, framing both Wethern and the Leton Corporation. Wethern is arrested, but she has gained a powerful enemy working against the Corporation. She gains “Wannabe Hacker” to her skills. Maybe Melina can mentor her!

Credits

Recluse Engine (CC BY 4.0) by Graven Utterance and Tiny Solitary Soldier Oracle for the main resolution and scene mechanics.

Freeform Universal Roleplaying Game (CC BY 4.0) by Nathan Russell as an inspiration of the whole game and the character traits.

Harm mechanics are from 6Q System (CC BY 4.0) by Marcus Burggraf.

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